

Smaller, Zippier:

A laser printer is still a significant investment—and not least because of its running costs. You certainly need help choosing one, and help is right here! Read on...

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Being as expensive as they were initially, laser printers were only to be seen in large offices. Besides, early laser printers were huge, and occupied entire desktops. Few at the time—the mid 1990s—would have imagined a laser printer shootout like the one that follows, for the Small office / Home office (SoHo) segment. Costs have indeed dropped drastically. And so has the cost per printed page, which is now less than a rupee. They've gotten smaller, too: one can now buy laser printers as small as a cubic foot.

Roughly speaking, monochrome laser printers—with the exception of a few that are meant for office use—are reasonably affordable, and colour lasers are still on the expensive side. Even if the colour printer itself is affordable, the running costs are too much for the typical home user: a colour cartridge costs nearly Rs 6,000, and a printer needs three colour cartridges/toners in addition to a black toner.

In what follows, we've compared affordable and compact monochrome laser printers from Brother, Canon, Epson, Samsung and Xerox—one from each manufacturer—all of which are targeted at the home user segment. We also have two heavy-duty printers from Brother and Xerox, but these were not compared with the rest, since they are meant for office use. See the boxes on the Brother HL-6050 DN and the Xerox Phaser 3425 for information on these.

In the colour laser printer section of this test, we had three printers—one each from Brother, Canon and Epson—set against each other.

We hope this test takes some of the guesswork out of the decision making if you're opting for a laser printer.

MONO LASER PRINTERS

The cost of an inkjet printer may be less than that of a mono laser printer, but the cost of printing isn't—and that's why getting yourself a mono laser makes sense, assuming you do a lot of printing.

Features Resolution And Memory

A salesperson for a printer may tell you about high resolutions, great processors, and lots of memory. These factors are indeed very important, but are not the only considerations.

The resolution of a printer determines the precision of the prints—technically, it indicates the sharpness of pixel reproduction on paper. Most of the printers we tested support a resolution of 600 x 600 dpi; Brother's HL-5170 DN and Canon's LBP2900 are a notch ahead, supporting 2400 x 600 dpi.

The installed memory and processor play an important role in the speed of the printer. The installed memory on the Epson EPL-6200L is the lowest in the category at 2 MB, whereas Brother's HL-5170DN has a remarkable 32 MB. The others feature 8 MB of memory, which is sufficient for a home user.

Build Quality

Both Samsung's ML-2010 and the Xerox Phaser 3117 were compact, but seemed fragile, especially the input trays. At the other end, the Brother HL-5170 is the most rugged.

Indicators And Buttons

An LCD screen on a printer is very useful, especially for sig-

nalling problems with a print job or with the printer itself. However, none of the printers have one—except for the two heavy-duty ones which we've covered separately. Except for the Canon LBP2900, all the others have more than one LED; of these, one was dedicated to error signalling. The Epson EPL 6200L doesn't have any buttons except for an on/off switch, so job cancellation can only be done from the computer. Brother's HL-5170 has three LED indicators, and buttons that can be used to cancel and pause/resume a print job.



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